

Licensed early childhood services

June 2025 ECE Census results¹

There were
4,390

licensed early childhood services².

61%

of licensed early childhood services were education
and care services.

40%

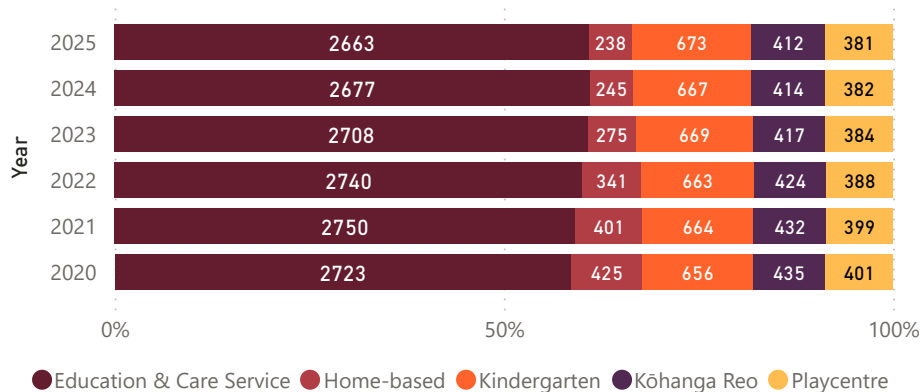
of licensed ECE services reported having a wait list,³
a decrease from 44% in 2024.

In 2025, occupancy rates for education and care services remained at 82%. Occupancy rates for kindergartens decreased to 85% and playcentres decreased to 57%.⁴

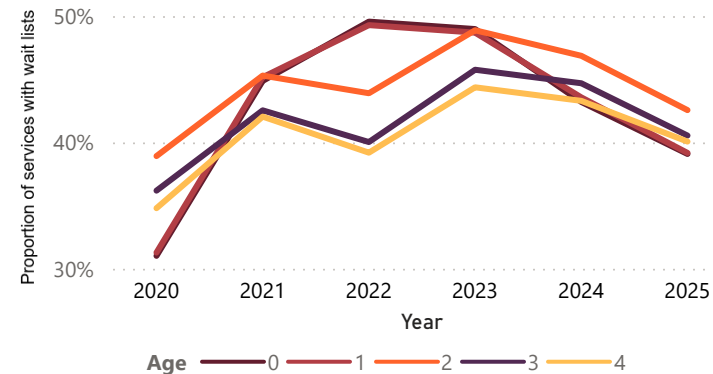
In 2025, capacity rates for education and care services remained at 58%. Capacity rates for kindergartens decreased to 74% and playcentres decreased to 49%.⁵

- There has been a 0.4% decrease in the number of licensed early childhood services since 2024; decreasing from 4,408 in 2024 to 4,390 in 2025.
- The number of education and care services decreased from 2,677 in 2024 to 2,663 in 2025 (0.5% decrease).
- The number of kindergartens increased from 667 in 2024 to 673 in 2025 (1% increase).
- Since 2024, there has been a decrease in licensed home-based services (3% decrease), kōhanga reo (0.5% decrease) and playcentre (0.3% decrease).

Number of licensed early learning services by service type



Proportion of early learning services with wait lists by child age



- In 2025, the proportion of services with wait lists for children aged under 2 decreased compared to 2024 (a 4 pp⁶ decrease for under 1-year-olds and a 4 pp decrease for 1-year-olds).
- The proportion of services with wait lists for children aged 2 or over decreased (a 4 pp decrease for 2-year-olds, a 4 pp decrease for 3-year-olds and a 3 pp decrease for 4-year-olds), compared to 2024.

- For children aged 1, the proportion of services with wait lists increased in 4 out of 16 regions.

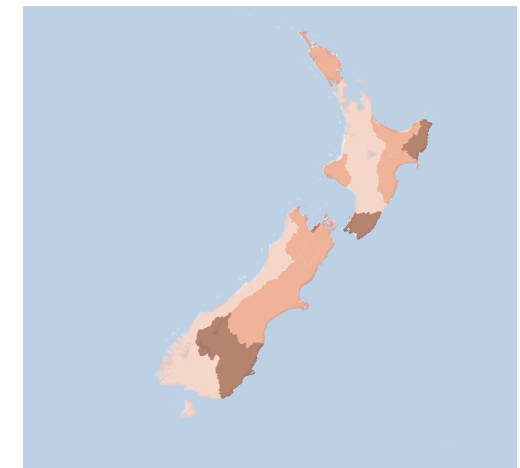
- The Wellington Region had the highest percentage of services with wait lists (58%) for children aged 1. The Southland Region had the smallest (28%).

- For children aged 4, the proportion of services with wait lists increased in 1 region.

- The Otago Region had the highest percentage of services with wait lists (58%) for children aged 4. Auckland Region had the smallest percentage (30%).

Proportion of services with a wait list, across all ages

30-39% 40-49% 50-59%



¹This data is from the Ministry of Education's annual Early Childhood Census, held from 23-29 June 2025. Further information can be found on [Education Counts](#). ²Playgroups and Te Kura (the Correspondence School) are not classified as licensed early childhood services by the Ministry of Education and therefore are excluded from this analysis. Ngā moana reo services (puna reo, reo rua education and care, leo o fanau moana bilingual and leo o fanau moana immersion) are included in the education and care service type.

³Occupancy rates and wait list data do not include Te Kura, licensed home-based services, or Kōhanga Reo. ⁴Occupancy rates indicate licensed places filled by children attending on a given day, averaged across all services in a category. ⁵Capacity rates indicate actual child attendance hours compared to the total possible hours based on licensed places and operating times. ⁶PP is short for percentage point.